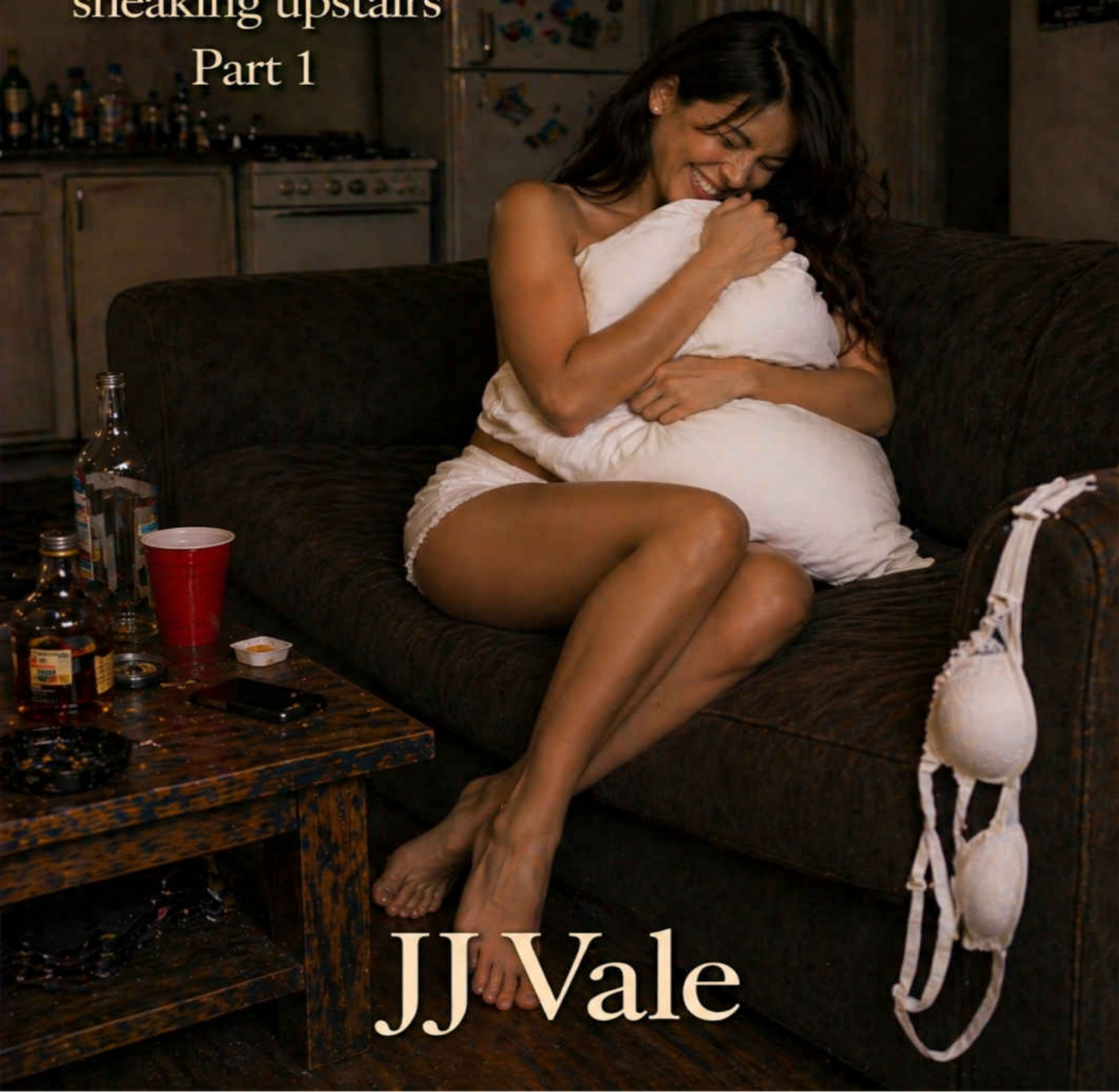


Confessions of a *Cheating Girlfriend I*

Lies, lust, and
sneaking upstairs

Part 1



JJ Vale

Confessions of a Cheating Girlfriend

Lies, lust, and sneaking upstairs

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PMI

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I heard his footsteps on the stairs before I saw him. The old wooden treads creaked in a pattern I had come to recognize over the past month, heavy, measured, the gait of someone who carried himself with certainty. I was pulling damp sheets from the building washer, my arms full of cold cotton, when Myles appeared in the doorway of the laundry room.

"Hey," he said.

I looked up. "Hey."

He carried a red mesh bag slung over his shoulder. The fluorescent light caught the angles of his face and I noticed for the first time that his eyes were more green than brown. He was taller than Silas, broader through the shoulders. I looked back at the sheets.

"You live in 8, right?" he asked.

"The basement apartment, yeah." I shoved the sheets into the dryer, reaching for the quarters I'd left on top of the machine. "You're upstairs somewhere?"

"12. Corner unit." He set his bag down and started sorting darks from lights on the folding table. "I've seen you coming and going. You and your boyfriend."

The word boyfriend hung there between us. I fed quarters into the slot and turned the dial. The dryer rumbled to life.

"Silas," I said. "He's in grad school. Urban planning."

"That explains all the books I see him carrying."

I had seen Myles jogging past our bedroom window in the mornings, had heard his footsteps late at night, had noticed his car, a dark blue Accord with a dent in the rear bumper, in the driveway. I had noticed him the way you notice weather patterns or the phases of the moon, without intention or consequence.

"What do you do?" I asked.

"Personal trainer. I work at the gym on Cascade." He loaded the washer with the ease of someone who had done this task a thousand times. "You?"

"Barista. The Third Rail, on campus."

"I've been there. You make a solid cortado."

I smiled despite myself. "You remember my drinks?"

"I remember faces." He added detergent and closed the lid. "And yours is easy to remember."

The compliment landed between us like something physical. I felt my face warm and hated myself for it. I gathered my empty basket and moved toward the stairs.

"See you around," I said.

"Yeah," he said. "See you around." I could feel his eyes on me as I left.

Silas was at the kitchen table when I came back to our apartment, his laptop open, three reference books stacked beside him. He didn't look up when I entered. I put the basket on the couch and went to the sink to fill a glass with water.

"Dryer's running," I said. "Forty minutes."

"Mm." His eyes stayed on the screen.

I drank the water and watched him. We had been together for three years, living together for one. The apartment was dim even in daylight, all our windows set high in the walls, half-below ground level. Silas said it was temporary, that once he finished his thesis we would move somewhere better, somewhere with natural light and a real bedroom instead of this converted basement with its concrete floors and persistent smell of mildew. I believed him because I wanted to, because believing him was easier than examining what I actually wanted.

"I met the guy from upstairs," I said. "12."

"Hmm?"

"Myles. He was doing laundry."

Silas typed something, deleted it, typed again. "That's nice."

I set the glass in the sink and looked at the back of his head, at the way his hair curled at his collar because he kept neglecting to get it cut. I loved him. But standing there in our dim apartment, I felt the weight of that love like something I carried rather than something that lifted me.

"I'm going to take a shower," I said.

He nodded without turning around.

The bathroom was small, the shower stall smaller. I stood under the hot water and thought about green eyes and the word boyfriend and how Myles had said my face was easy to remember. I thought about these things the way you think about a bruise you're not ready to acknowledge, pressing on it just to feel it hurt.

Three days passed before I saw him again. I was coming home from my shift at the coffee shop, my hair smelling like espresso and burnt milk, my feet aching in the canvas shoes. The front door of the house opened just as I

reached it, and Myles stepped out wearing running shorts and a tank top, his skin gleaming with sweat.

"Briana," he said, and I realized he had learned my name.

"Just finishing?" I gestured at his clothes.

"Six miles. Working up to a half marathon in October." He held the door open for me. "How was work?"

"The usual. College students who don't tip and don't know what they want."

He laughed. It was a good laugh, genuine and unguarded. "I'll make sure to tip better next time."

We stood in the shared entryway, me in my coffee-stained apron, him in his running gear. The space was too small for us not to be close. I could smell his sweat, clean and salt-sharp, could see the way his chest rose and fell.

"I should let you get to your shower," I said.

"And I should let you get home." But he didn't move. "Although if you ever want company doing laundry, I'm around most evenings."

"I'll keep that in mind."

I went down the stairs to our apartment, and I didn't look back, but I felt his eyes on me the whole way down.

Silas was on the couch, reading. He looked up when I entered.

"You're late," he said. Not accusing, just observing.

"Rachel needed me to stay an extra hour. Someone called in sick." The lie came without effort, smooth and complete. I had left on time. I had simply walked the long way home, thinking about the way Myles looked at me.

"There's leftover pasta in the fridge."

"I'm not that hungry." I dropped my bag by the door and sat beside him. "What are you reading?"

He showed me the cover. Something about sustainable urban development. I rested my head on his shoulder and he put his arm around me, and we sat like that while he read and I stared at nothing, my mind already climbing the stairs to apartment 12.

As if.

That night I couldn't sleep. Silas breathed beside me, deep and regular, his back to me in the darkness. I stared at the ceiling and listened to footsteps overhead. Someone was walking back and forth, back and forth. I

told myself it could be anyone. The house had four apartments above us. But I knew the weight of those steps, the rhythm of that gait.

At two in the morning I got up and went to the bathroom. I looked at myself in the mirror under the harsh light. My hair was tangled, my face pale. I was twenty-four years old and I worked at a coffee shop and lived in a basement and had a boyfriend who loved urban planning more than he loved me, it felt like. I said this last part out loud, just to hear how it sounded.

It sounded true.

I went back to bed and lay awake until dawn.

The next time I did laundry, I waited until evening. I told Silas I was going to wash sheets, and he nodded without looking away from his laptop. I had showered first. I had put on mascara. I had chosen a tank top that fit well and jeans that sat low on my hips. I told myself these choices meant nothing.

Myles was already there when I arrived, folding a pile of white t-shirts. He looked up and smiled.

"Right on schedule," he said.

"You were expecting me?"

"Hoping, maybe." He set down the shirt he was holding. "Want help with those?"

I let him take the basket from me. Our fingers brushed. The contact lasted less than a second but I felt it in my stomach, a quick drop like missing a step in the dark.

We loaded the machines side by side. He asked me about work and I asked him about training, and we fell into conversation the way water finds a channel. He told me about his clients, the ones who wanted shortcuts and the ones who actually put in the work. I told him about the regular customers at the coffee shop, their orders and their habits. We talked about nothing important, but the talking itself felt important, felt necessary in a way that conversation with Silas had stopped feeling months ago.

"How long have you lived here?" I asked.

"Two months. Moved from Portland after my mom got sick. She's better now, but I stayed. The city suits me." He leaned against the washing machine, his arms crossed. "You?"

"A year. We moved in together after he started grad school."

"We," he repeated. "You and the boyfriend."

"Silas," I said. "His name is Silas."

"Right. Silas." He held my gaze. "Is he good to you?"

The question caught me off guard. "What kind of question is that?"

"A simple one."

I should have been offended. I should have said it was none of his business. Instead I looked at the washing machine, at the clothes spinning behind the glass, around and around.

"He's distracted," I said. "His thesis. It takes everything."

"And what do you get?"

"What I need." But I said it too quickly, and we both knew it was a lie.

The dryer buzzed. Myles pushed off from the washer and began pulling out his clothes, shaking them flat before folding them. I watched his hands, the sureness of his movements.

"You don't have to settle for distracted," he said, not looking at me.

"I'm not settling."

"If you say so."

My clothes finished washing and I moved them to the dryer. Myles finished folding and loaded his basket. He should have left then. He had no reason to stay. But he sat on the folding table, legs dangling, and watched me measure out detergent for the next load.

"What made you move in with him?" he asked.

"We'd been together two years. It made sense. My lease was up, he needed a place near campus. Practical reasons."

"Those the only reasons?"

I turned to face him. "Why are you asking me this?"

"Because I'm curious about you." He said it simply, as if it explained everything. "Because I want to know what you're doing in a basement apartment with a guy who doesn't look at you."

The air changed. Something that had been circling finally landed.

"You don't know anything about us," I said.

"I know he left you alone on a Friday night to do laundry. I know he didn't come with you. I know you're standing here talking to me instead of going back."

"I should go."

"You should stay."

"My dryer has thirty minutes left."

"Then stay thirty minutes." He slid off the table and moved closer. Not touching me, but close enough that I had to tilt my head to meet his eyes. "Talk to me, Briana. Just talking."

So I stayed. I sat on the folding table where he had been sitting and I talked. I told him about growing up in Sacramento, about my parents who divorced when I was twelve, about my sister who lived in Seattle and called once a month out of obligation. I told him about dropping out of college after a year because I couldn't see the point, about drifting through jobs until I landed at the coffee shop, about how I told myself this was temporary but temporary had stretched into three years.

He listened without interrupting. When I finished, he told me about his father who had left when he was eight, about playing football in high school and blowing out his knee senior year, about the scholarship he lost and the community college he attended instead. He told me about learning to train people the way he wished someone had trained him, about building something from nothing.

We talked until my dryer stopped, and then we talked while I folded my sheets. We talked until the laundry room felt smaller than it was, until the space between us felt charged with something

"I should really go now," I said, my basket full and balanced on my hip.

"Same time next week?" he asked.

"I don't know."

"I'll be here either way."

I went and I didn't look back, but I knew he was watching.

Silas was asleep on the couch, his laptop still open on his chest. I set down the laundry and stood looking at him. His face in sleep was younger, softer. I remembered the first time we met, at a party neither of us wanted to be at, how we had ended up on the balcony talking about nothing and everything. I remembered how he had kissed me at the end of the night, gentle and tentative, and how I had thought this could be something good.

It had been something good, for a while.

I closed his laptop and covered him with the throw blanket from the back of the couch. He stirred but didn't wake. I went to the bedroom and lay down alone in the dark, thinking about green eyes and questions I shouldn't have answered and the thirty minutes I should not have stayed.

Three days later I saw Myles in the driveway. I was leaving for work and he was getting out of his car, a gym bag over his shoulder. He waved. I

waved back. That should have been all.

Instead I found myself walking over.

"Early session?" I asked.

"Late one. I had a six AM client." He rolled his shoulders, stretching.

"You heading to work?"

"Yeah. I'm on at nine."

"The Third Rail, right? I might stop by later."

"You don't have to do that."

"I know I don't have to." He smiled. "What if I want to?"

I should have said something discouraging. I should have established boundaries. Instead I said, "I get a break at eleven."

"I'll see you at eleven."

He came at eleven exactly. I saw him through the window before he entered, watched him cross the street with that easy confidence, and my heart kicked against my ribs. I was wiping down the espresso machine when he walked in. Rachel was on register. She looked at him, then at me, then back at him.

"I've got this one," I said.

She raised an eyebrow but stepped aside.

Myles leaned against the counter. "Cortado, right? Since you remember I like them."

"I remember." I pulled the shot and steamed the milk, aware of his eyes on me the whole time. My hands were steady but something inside me was not. I set the cup in front of him.

"What do I owe you?"

"It's on me."

"Then I'm leaving a really good tip." He slid a ten across the counter.

"That's too much."

"It's exactly right." He picked up the cup. "When's your break?"

I glanced at the clock. "Now, actually."

"Then take it with me."

I looked around. The morning rush had passed. Three customers sat scattered at tables, all absorbed in their laptops. Rachel was restocking pastries and pretending not to listen. I untied my apron.

"Fifteen minutes," I told her.

"Take twenty," she said, still not looking at us.

Outside, the sun was bright and warm. Summer was settling into the city, the kind of heat that made everything feel slow and possible. We walked without direction, ending up on a bench outside the student bookstore.

"Tell me something true," Myles said.

"What kind of thing?"

"Anything. Something you don't usually say out loud."

I thought about it. "I'm tired of making coffee for people who don't see me."

"They see you. They just don't look." He drank from his cup. "What else?"

"I'm twenty-four and I have no idea what I'm doing with my life."

"That makes two of us."

"You seem like you have it figured out."

He laughed. "I get paid to tell people how to lift weights. I'm not exactly changing the world."

"But you like it."

"I do." He turned to face me. "Do you like anything about your life right now?"

The question was too big, too direct. I watched a group of students cross the street, backpacks heavy, faces turned toward phones.

"I like this," I said. "Right now. Sitting here."

"Then we should do it more often."

"Myles."

"What?"

"You know what."

He set down his cup. "Say it then. Whatever you're thinking."

"I have a boyfriend."

"I know. You've mentioned him several times. Silas, who studies urban planning and leaves you alone at night."

"That's not fair."

"What's not fair is you pretending this isn't happening." He gestured between us. "This. Whatever this is."

"Nothing is happening."

"Tell me you don't think about our conversations. Tell me you didn't put on mascara before work today hoping I'd show up."

I felt heat in my face. "You're reading into things."

"Am I?" He leaned back, studying me. "Okay. I'll back off. But answer one question first, and answer it honestly."

"What?"

"When was the last time Silas looked at you the way I'm looking at you right now?"

I stood up. "I need to get back to work."

"Briana."

"Thanks for stopping by."

I walked away before he could say anything else, my hands shaking, my throat tight. I heard him call my name but I didn't turn around.

Back inside the coffee shop, Rachel looked at me and said nothing. I tied my apron and threw myself into work, cleaning things that didn't need cleaning, reorganizing things that were already organized.

But I couldn't stop thinking about his question.

When was the last time Silas looked at me the way Myles had been looking at me?

I couldn't remember.

That evening I tried. I made dinner, something I hadn't done in weeks. Pasta with vegetables and garlic bread. I set the table with actual plates instead of eating on the couch. I put on music. When Silas emerged from his study corner, he looked surprised.

"What's all this?"

"Dinner. I thought we could eat together."

"Oh. Yeah, okay." He sat down, but his phone was in his hand. "This looks great."

We ate. I asked about his thesis. He told me about zoning regulations and density requirements and transit-oriented development. His eyes lit up when he talked about these things, the way they used to light up when he talked to me. I watched him and tried to feel what I used to feel, tried to find the connection we used to have.

"How was your day?" he asked, finally.

"Fine. Busy."

"Good tips?"

"Some."

He nodded and went back to his pasta. The music played. The conversation died. After a while he said, "I have a meeting with my advisor tomorrow. I should probably review my notes tonight."

"Sure. Of course."

He finished eating and carried his plate to the sink, kissed the top of my head, and went back to his laptop. I sat alone at the table we never used and admitted something to myself I had been avoiding for months.

We were roommates who slept in the same bed. Nothing more.

I didn't go to the laundry room for a week. I washed our clothes at a laundromat three blocks away, spending money we didn't have on machines that cost twice as much, just to avoid running into Myles. I told myself I was being smart, setting boundaries, protecting what I had with Silas.

But on Friday evening, carrying a basket of dirty towels, I found myself climbing the stairs to our shared laundry room.

He was there. Of course he was there. He looked up when I entered, and something in his expression told me he had been waiting.

"Thought maybe you'd moved," he said.

"Just busy."

"Right. Busy."

I loaded the washer in silence. He didn't move from where he sat on the folding table. The air felt different than it had before, heavier with things unsaid.

"I was out of line," he said finally. "Last week. I pushed too hard."

"Yes, you did."

"I'm sorry."

I turned to face him. "Are you?"

"No." He smiled, but it wasn't a happy smile. "I'm not sorry for what I said. I'm sorry it upset you. But I'm not sorry for saying what's true."

"You don't know what's true. You don't know me."

"Then let me know you." He slid off the table and moved closer. "That's all I'm asking. Let me know you."

"We barely know each other."

"We could fix that."

The washer filled with water behind me, a rushing sound that filled the silence. I should have left. I should have walked out right then, gone back downstairs, deleted this from my life before it became something I couldn't delete.

Instead I said, "What do you want from me?"

"Honestly?" He was close enough now that I could see the flecks of gold in his green eyes. "I want to know what makes you laugh. I want to know

what you think about at three in the morning. I want to take you somewhere that isn't a basement apartment or a laundry room and watch you be yourself without looking over your shoulder."

"I can't."

"Why not?"

"Because I'm with someone."

"Are you though?" He didn't touch me, but I felt the pull of him like gravity. "Are you really with him, Briana? Or are you just next to him?"

I didn't answer. I couldn't answer. The question opened up something I had been carefully keeping closed.

"Just coffee," he said. "Tomorrow afternoon. As friends. Tell me no and I'll drop this completely. Tell me yes and we'll go somewhere and talk. That's all."

"That's not all."

"No," he admitted. "It's not. But it's where we start."

The washer clicked and hummed, moving from fill cycle to wash. I watched the soapy water slosh behind the glass and thought about how easy it would be to say no. One word. Two letters. I could say it and end this before it became something I couldn't end.

"Where?" I asked.

"There's a coffee shop on Meridian. Not the one you work at. Somewhere we won't know anyone."

"What time?"

"Two. I have a client at noon, you work mornings on Saturday."

"You know my schedule."

"I pay attention." He stepped back, giving me space. "Is that a yes?"

"It's a maybe."

"I'll take it." He grabbed his empty basket from the corner. "I'll be there at two. If you show up, you show up. If you don't, I'll understand."

He left before I could say anything else. I stood in the laundry room until my washer finished its cycle, then I moved the clothes to the dryer and sat on the folding table where he had been sitting. The metal was still warm from his body.

I sat there for the full forty-minute dry cycle, thinking about choices and consequences and the difference between what you want and what you should do.

I told Silas I was picking up an extra shift. The lie came easier this time, settled into place without resistance. He was working on a presentation for his advisor and barely looked up when I said it.

"Will you be back for dinner?" he asked.

"Probably not. Don't wait up."

"Okay. There's leftover Chinese in the fridge."

I showered and stood in front of my closet for twenty minutes. Everything felt too deliberate. The blue dress said I was trying. The jeans and t-shirt said I didn't care. I settled on jeans and a fitted white shirt, simple and clean. I put on makeup, then wiped most of it off, then put it back on again. I was meeting a friend for coffee. That was all. People did that.

People lied to themselves too.

The coffee shop on Meridian was small and crowded, full of weekend energy. I saw Myles through the window before I went in. He sat at a corner table, watching the door. When he saw me his whole face changed, opened up into something I felt in my chest.

I almost turned around.

Instead I pushed through the door and walked to his table. He stood when I approached.

"You came," he said.

"I'm here."

"Sit. I'll get you something. What do you want?"

"I can get my own coffee."

"I know you can. Let me do it anyway."

I told him my order and he went to the counter. I sat and looked around the shop, half expecting to see someone I knew, someone who would see me here with him and understand what this meant. But the faces were all strangers. I was anonymous here. Free.

He came back with two cups and a chocolate croissant on a plate.

"You didn't eat lunch," he said, setting it in front of me.

"How do you know?"

"Because you never do on Saturdays. You told me. You work the morning shift and you're too tired when you get off, so you just come home and crash."

The fact that he had remembered this, had filed it away and retrieved it, made something in my chest tighten.

"Thank you," I said.

We drank our coffee. The conversation started slow, careful, both of us aware we were walking on uncertain ground. He asked about work and I asked about his clients. Safe topics, friend topics. But there was nothing safe about the way he looked at me, the way his attention never wavered.

"Tell me about when you were a kid," he said. "Before everything got complicated."

So I told him about summers in Sacramento, about my best friend Jenny who moved away in sixth grade, about the tree house my father built before the divorce. I told him about wanting to be a veterinarian until I realized it meant dealing with death, about my obsession with astronomy that lasted exactly one semester.

He told me about growing up in Portland, about his mother working two jobs to keep them afloat, about teaching himself to cook because she was never home for dinner. He told me about the injury that ended football, about watching his teammates go off to universities while he stayed behind.

"Do you regret it?" I asked. "The way things turned out?"

"I used to. I spent a year angry at everyone and everything. Then I realized anger was just keeping me stuck." He turned his cup in his hands. "What about you? Do you regret dropping out?"

"Sometimes. Mostly I regret not knowing what I wanted in the first place."

"What do you want now?"

There it was again. The direct question, the demand for truth.

"I don't know," I said. "I thought I wanted stability. A relationship that made sense. A life that looked right from the outside."

"And does it? Look right?"

"On paper, maybe."

"What about in reality?"

I broke off a piece of croissant, pressed my thumb into the flaky layers. "In reality I live in a basement and make coffee and go days without having a real conversation with my boyfriend."

"Why do you stay?"

"Because leaving feels harder than staying. Because I don't know what comes next. Because I love him." I said this last part to convince myself, but it sounded hollow even to my ears.

"Do you?" Myles asked. "Or do you love the idea of him?"

"That's not fair."

"Maybe not. But it's true, isn't it? He's safe. He's the right kind of guy, does the right kind of work, wants the right kind of future. But does he see you? Does he know you the way I'm starting to know you?"

"You don't know me. We've talked a few times."

"I know you play with your hair when you're nervous. I know you take your coffee black but you'll add cream if someone makes it for you because you don't want to seem difficult. I know you're left-handed but you learned to use scissors right-handed because no one bought you the left-handed kind. I know you hum when you think no one's listening."

I stared at him. "How do you know these things?"

"Because I pay attention. Because when I'm around you, you're all I see."

The coffee shop noise faded. The other customers disappeared. There was only him, looking at me like I was the answer to a question he'd been asking his whole life.

"We should go," I said.

"Why?"

"Because this is too much."

"It's only too much if you want it to be nothing."

I stood up. He stood with me. We walked out into the afternoon sun and I felt unsteady, like the ground had shifted beneath me.

"Can I walk you home?" he asked.

"No. I told Silas I was working."

"Then let me walk you somewhere. Anywhere."

We walked. No destination, just movement. Through neighborhoods I half-knew, past houses with gardens and children playing in yards. We didn't talk much. We didn't need to. The walking itself felt like conversation, like we were saying things without words.

After an hour we ended up at a park I had never been to before. There was a pond with ducks and a playground empty on a Saturday afternoon. We sat on a bench facing the water.

"I think about you," he said. "More than I should."

My heart was beating too fast. "Myles."

"I know. I know you're with him. I know this is complicated. But I can't stop thinking about you, Briana. About how you deserve better than what you're settling for."

"You don't know what I deserve."

"I know you deserve someone who notices when you're in the room. Someone who asks about your day and actually listens to the answer. Someone who looks at you and sees everything you are, not just what's convenient."

I turned to face him. "And you think you're that person?"

"I think I could be. If you let me."

The air between us felt electric, charged with possibility and danger. I should have stood up. Should have created distance. Instead I stayed exactly where I was.

"I should hate you for this," I said.

"Do you?"

"No."

"Then what do you feel?"

I looked at the water, at the ducks gliding across the surface, their movements so simple and sure. "I feel like I'm standing at the edge of something and if I step forward, everything changes."

"Everything's already changing," he said. "You just haven't admitted it yet."

He was right. I had admitted it to myself in small ways over the past weeks. Every time I put on mascara before going to the laundry room. Every time I checked the driveway to see if his car was there. Every time I lay awake listening to his footsteps overhead. The change had already started. I was just pretending it hadn't.

"I need to go home," I said.

"Okay."

"I mean it this time."

"I know." He stood and offered me his hand. I looked at it for a long moment before taking it. His palm was warm, his grip firm. He pulled me to my feet but didn't let go right away. We stood there, hands joined, and I felt the future splitting into two paths. One where I pulled away and went back to Silas and pretended this afternoon never happened. One where I held on and saw where it led.

I pulled away.

We walked back in silence. He didn't try to fill it with words and I was grateful for that. When we reached the corner of my street, I stopped.

"I can walk the rest alone," I said.

"When can I see you again?"

"I don't know if you should."

"But you want to."

It wasn't a question. He said it with certainty, and I couldn't contradict him because it was true.

"Monday," I said. "Laundry room. Same time as before."

"I'll be there."

I walked the last block alone. The house came into view, familiar and oppressive at once. I could see the high windows of our basement apartment, the dim light inside. Silas would be at his laptop. The leftover Chinese would still be in the fridge. Everything would be exactly as I left it.

Except I was different now.

I went down the stairs and opened the door. Silas was on the couch, exactly where I knew he would be. He looked up.

"You're back early," he said.

"They didn't need me after all. Someone's shift got covered."

The lie settled into place. He nodded and went back to his screen. I stood in the doorway watching him, this man I had built a life with, and felt nothing but distance.

"I'm going to take a shower," I said.

"Okay."

Under the hot water I pressed my palms against the tile and tried to make sense of what I was doing. I had crossed a line today. Not physically, but in every other way that mattered. I had sat with another man and told him truths I hadn't told my boyfriend in months. I had let him see me in a way I no longer let Silas see me. I had held his hand and felt more in that touch than I felt in a month of sleeping next to Silas.

I was cheating. Maybe not in the way that counted legally or technically, but in the way that counted in my chest, in the guilty knowledge that sat heavy behind my ribs.

And the worst part was I wanted to do it again.

Sunday crawled by. Silas worked on his presentation. I cleaned the apartment and went grocery shopping and made dinner we ate in front of the television. He fell asleep with his head on my shoulder and I sat there, trapped under his weight, thinking about green eyes and direct questions and the feeling of being truly seen.

Monday I woke up with purpose. I told myself I was just doing laundry. That was all. I needed clean clothes and the machines were upstairs and if

Myles happened to be there, we would talk like friends and nothing more.

I didn't believe it, but I told myself anyway.

At seven I climbed the stairs with my basket of darks. My heart kicked against my ribs. My hands felt unsteady. The laundry room was empty. I loaded my clothes and measured detergent and tried not to feel disappointed.

Then I heard footsteps on the stairs.

He appeared in the doorway with his red mesh bag. When he saw me his face opened into a smile that made my stomach drop.

"Hey," he said.

"Hi."

We loaded our machines in silence, but it was a different kind of silence than Saturday. This silence hummed with awareness, with things we both wanted to say and didn't. I could feel the space between us like something physical, like a force pulling us together that I was actively resisting.

"How was the rest of your weekend?" he asked.

"Fine. Quiet."

"Mine too." He closed the washer lid. "I kept thinking about Saturday."

"Myles."

"I know. I know we're supposed to be just friends. But friends don't think about each other the way I think about you."

I turned to face him. "What do you want me to say?"

"I want you to tell me I'm not alone in this. That you feel it too."

"Of course I feel it. That's the problem."

"Why is it a problem?"

"Because I have a boyfriend. Because this is wrong. Because I don't know how to stop it and that scares me."

He moved closer. Not touching, but close enough that I had to tilt my head back to meet his eyes. "Do you want to stop it?"

"I should want to."

"That's not what I asked."

The washing machines hummed and sloshed around us. The fluorescent light flickered. I could smell his soap, clean and fresh. I could see the pulse beating in his throat.

"No," I said. "I don't want to stop it."

Something shifted in his expression, satisfaction and desire mixed together. "Then don't."

"It's not that simple."

"It could be." He reached out and tucked a strand of hair behind my ear. The touch was brief, gentle, but it went through me like electricity. "You could just let yourself feel what you're feeling. Stop fighting it."

"And then what? I blow up my whole life for something that might not even be real?"

"It's real, Briana. This is the most real thing I've felt in years."

I stepped back, putting space between us before I did something I couldn't take back. "I need time to think."

"Take all the time you need. I'm not going anywhere." He leaned against the dryer, watching me. "But while you're thinking, ask yourself something. When was the last time you felt alive? Really alive, not just going through the motions?"

I didn't answer because I didn't need to. We both knew it was Saturday afternoon on a bench by a pond, sitting next to him.

My washer finished its cycle. I moved the clothes to the dryer with shaking hands. He watched me the whole time, his gaze steady and sure. When I was done I grabbed my empty basket.

"Same time next week?" he asked.

"I don't know."

"I'll be here anyway."

I went down the stairs feeling like I was falling, like gravity had shifted and I no longer knew which way was up. Silas was at the kitchen table, his laptop open. He didn't look up when I came in.

"Laundry done?" he asked.

"Still drying. Forty minutes."

"Mm."

I set down the basket and watched him type. His face was illuminated by the screen, his expression focused and distant. He was here but he wasn't here. He had been not-here for months, maybe longer. I had just been too comfortable to notice.

"Silas," I said.

"Yeah?" Still typing.

"Do you love me?"

His hands paused on the keyboard. He looked up, confusion on his face. "What kind of question is that?"

"A simple one."

"Of course I love you. Why are you asking?"

"When was the last time you told me?"

He thought about it. "I don't know. A few weeks ago?"

"Try three months."

"Briana, I'm in the middle of something. Can we talk about this later?"

"That's the problem. It's always later with you. Everything is always later."

He closed his laptop, giving me his attention for the first time in days. "Where is this coming from?"

"From the fact that we live together and barely speak. From the fact that you don't notice when I'm here or when I'm gone. From the fact that I could disappear tomorrow and you probably wouldn't realize until you needed clean laundry."

"That's not fair."

"Isn't it? When was the last time we had a conversation that wasn't about your thesis or what to eat for dinner?"

He stared at me. "I don't know. I've been busy. The thesis defense is in two months and my advisor is on my ass about the methodology section. You know this."

"I know." And I did know. I had known for months. But knowing didn't make it hurt less, didn't fill the empty space where our relationship used to be.

"Is something going on?" he asked. "You've been acting strange."

"Nothing's going on." The lie came automatically. "I'm just tired."

He studied me for another moment, then opened his laptop again. "We can talk more later. I really need to finish this section."

"Sure. Later."

I went to the bedroom and lay down on the bed. Through the ceiling I could hear footsteps. Myles, moving around his apartment. I closed my eyes and thought about the way he had touched my hair, the brief contact of his fingers against my skin. I thought about it until my dryer buzzed, and then I thought about it some more.

I stayed away from the laundry room for four days. I told myself I was being strong, making the right choice. But Thursday evening I found myself climbing the stairs with a basket of clothes that weren't even dirty yet.

He was there. He was always there.

"You're early this week," he said.

"Needed to wash some things."

He nodded like he believed me. We loaded our machines without talking. The silence felt different this time, heavier with want. I could feel him watching me. When I bent to add detergent, when I closed the washer lid, when I turned around.

"Come here," he said.

It wasn't a question. It was an invitation and a challenge at once. I should have said no. Should have stayed where I was, safe on my side of the room.

I crossed to him.

He was leaning against the folding table. When I got close enough he reached out and put his hands on my waist. The touch sent heat through me, immediate and consuming.

"Tell me to stop," he said.

I didn't tell him to stop.

He pulled me closer, fitting me between his legs. His hands were warm through my shirt. I put my palms on his chest and felt his heart beating, fast and hard.

"Briana," he said, and my name in his mouth sounded like something sacred.

I kissed him.

I didn't think about it. Didn't weigh consequences or consider outcomes. I just leaned forward and pressed my mouth to his and felt everything else fall away.

He made a sound low in his throat and pulled me tighter against him. His mouth opened under mine and I tasted him, coffee and something sweet. His hands slid up my back, into my hair. I gripped his shirt and felt the solid muscle beneath it.

The kiss deepened. His tongue touched mine and I felt it everywhere, a current running through my whole body. One of his hands moved to my hip, his thumb pressing against bare skin where my shirt had ridden up. The contact made me gasp.

He pulled back, breathing hard. "We should stop."

"I know."

"Your boyfriend is right downstairs."

"I know."

"If we keep going, "

I kissed him again. Harder this time, with purpose. He groaned and lifted me, setting me on the folding table. I wrapped my legs around him and felt him hard against me through our jeans. The knowledge of his want made something in me break open.

His mouth moved to my neck. He kissed the soft skin below my ear and I arched into him, my head falling back. His hands were on my thighs, sliding higher, and I wanted them everywhere. I wanted his hands and his mouth and all of him.

"God, you're perfect," he said against my skin.

I pulled his face back to mine and kissed him until we were both breathing hard. His hand cupped my breast through my shirt and I made a sound I didn't recognize, desperate and needy.

The washing machine buzzed.

We both froze. The sound cut through the haze of want, sharp and insistent. Reality crashed back. I was sitting on a folding table in a laundry room, wrapped around a man who wasn't my boyfriend, my shirt halfway up my ribs.

I scrambled off the table. Myles caught my arm.

"Briana, wait, "

"I have to go."

"Don't run. Not this time."

But I was already moving toward the door. My lips felt swollen. My skin felt hot. I could still taste him in my mouth.

"I'll see you," he called after me.

I didn't answer. I ran down the stairs and into the apartment, my heart slamming against my ribs. Silas was exactly where I had left him, at the table with his laptop. He looked up.

"That was fast," he said.

"What?"

"The laundry. You just went up."

"Oh. Yeah. I forgot detergent. I'll go back later."

He nodded and returned to his screen. I went to the bathroom and locked the door. In the mirror my face was flushed, my eyes bright. I looked like someone who had just been thoroughly kissed. I looked alive.

I pressed my hands to my face and tried to breathe normally. I had crossed a line. Not just crossed it, I had demolished it. And the worst part,

the part that made shame curl hot in my stomach, was that I wanted to do it again.

I wanted to go back upstairs right now. I wanted to finish what we started. I wanted his hands on my skin and his mouth on mine and I didn't care that Silas was twenty feet away, didn't care about consequences or guilt or the future.

I wanted.

That was the truth underneath everything else. I wanted Myles in a way I hadn't wanted anything in years. The wanting felt bigger than sense, bigger than loyalty, bigger than the life I had carefully built.

I washed my face with cold water and went back out. Silas was still typing. I sat on the couch and picked up my phone and tried to act normal. But I could still feel Myles's hands on my waist, could still taste him in my mouth.

At midnight Silas came to bed. He kissed my forehead and rolled onto his side. Within minutes he was asleep. I lay awake in the dark and touched my lips, remembering.

Friday morning I called in sick to work. I couldn't face the routine, couldn't pretend everything was normal. Rachel sounded skeptical but didn't push. Silas left for campus at eight. As soon as his car pulled out of the driveway, I went upstairs.

I knocked on apartment 12.

Myles opened the door wearing sweatpants and nothing else. When he saw me, something flickered across his face, surprise, then heat.

"Hey," he said.

"Can I come in?"

He stepped aside. I walked into his apartment for the first time. It was neat, spare, the space of someone who didn't own much or care about decoration. A couch, a coffee table, weights in the corner. The bedroom door was open, the bed unmade.

"I didn't expect to see you," he said.

"I didn't expect to come."

We stood in his living room looking at each other. The air felt charged, dangerous. I should leave. I should go back downstairs and forget this ever happened.

Instead I moved toward him.

He met me halfway. This time there was no hesitation. His mouth found mine and I sank into the kiss, into the heat of his bare skin under my hands. He walked me backward until my shoulders hit the wall. His body pressed against mine, all lean muscle and want.

"Tell me to stop," he said again.

"No."

His hand slid under my shirt, palm flat against my stomach. I sucked in a breath. He watched my face as his hand moved higher, over my ribs, cupping my breast through my bra. His thumb brushed across my nipple and I gasped.

"You're so responsive," he said. "Does he know that about you? Does he know how you sound when you're touched?"

"Don't talk about him."

"Why not? He's why you're here, isn't he? Because he doesn't see you. Doesn't touch you like this."

He wasn't wrong. But I didn't want to think about Silas. Didn't want to think about anything except the way Myles's hands felt on my skin.

I pulled his mouth back to mine. He groaned and lifted me. I wrapped my legs around his waist and he carried me to the couch, settling me on his lap. I could feel him hard beneath me and I rolled my hips, seeking friction.

"Christ," he breathed.

His hands were everywhere, my back, my thighs, my hair. I pulled off my shirt and his eyes went dark. He unhooked my bra with practiced ease and tossed it aside. For a moment he just looked at me, and the hunger in his gaze made me feel powerful.

Then his mouth was on my breast and I stopped thinking entirely.

I arched into him, my fingers tangling in his hair. His tongue circled my nipple and I made sounds I had never made before, desperate and raw. His hand slid up my thigh, fingers pressing against me through my jeans, and I ground down against his palm.

"Bedroom," I managed.

He stood with me still wrapped around him and carried me through the door. The bed was unmade, sheets tangled. He laid me down and I pulled him with me, needing his weight, his heat. He kissed me while his hands worked at the button of my jeans. I lifted my hips and he pulled them down, taking my underwear with them.

I was naked beneath him. Exposed. He knelt between my legs and just looked, his hands running up my thighs, his thumbs brushing the sensitive skin at the crease of my hip.

"You're beautiful," he said.

I reached for the waistband of his sweatpants but he caught my wrist.

"Not yet," he said. "I want to take my time with you."

His mouth moved down my body. He kissed my collarbone, the valley between my breasts, my stomach. His hands followed, tracing patterns on my skin. When he reached my thighs he spread them wider, settling between them. His breath was hot against me.

"Tell me if you want me to stop," he said.

I didn't want him to stop.

His mouth on me was nothing like I had experienced before. Silas had done this maybe three times in three years, perfunctory and rushed. This was different. Myles took his time, exploring with his tongue, learning what made my breath catch. His hands gripped my thighs, holding me open for him.

The pleasure built slowly, then faster. My hands fisted in the sheets. I bit my lip to keep from making noise but small sounds escaped anyway. His tongue moved in circles, then long strokes, then he sucked gently and my back arched off the bed.

"God," I breathed.

He slid two fingers inside me while his mouth continued its work. The dual sensation made my thighs shake. He curved his fingers, finding a spot that made stars burst behind my eyes. I gripped his hair, my hips moving against his face.

The tension built and built, coiling tight in my core. His fingers moved faster, his tongue relentless. I felt myself climbing toward something, chasing it, my whole body taut. Then it broke over me in waves that made me cry out, my body pulsing around his fingers, pleasure flooding through me in surges I couldn't control.

He worked me through it, gentling as I came down. When I could breathe again he kissed his way back up my body, his mouth finding mine. I could taste myself on his tongue.

"Your turn," I said.

I pushed him onto his back and straddled him. He was hard beneath his sweatpants, the fabric tented. I ground down against him and he groaned. I

kissed him while I rocked my hips, feeling him through the thin material.

"Take these off," I said.

He lifted his hips and I pulled the sweatpants down. He wore nothing underneath. He was thick and hard, a bead of moisture at the tip. I wrapped my hand around him and he sucked in a breath.

"Christ, Briana."

I stroked him slowly, learning the feel of him. He was hot and smooth in my palm. I watched his face as I worked him, the way his jaw clenched, the way his eyes went dark.

"Use your mouth," he said.

I lowered myself between his legs. I had never enjoyed this with Silas, had always felt awkward and uncertain. But with Myles I wanted it. I wanted to taste him, to make him feel what he had made me feel.

I took him in my mouth and his hand went to my hair. Not pushing, just holding. I started slow, finding my rhythm. He was too big to take all of him but I did what I could, using my hand on what didn't fit. His hips lifted slightly and I took it as encouragement.

"Just like that," he said, his voice strained. "That's perfect."

I increased my pace, hollowing my cheeks, using my tongue. His grip tightened in my hair. His breathing turned ragged. I could feel him getting closer, his thighs tensing under my hands.

"Briana, I'm going to, "

I didn't pull away. I kept going until he was pulsing in my mouth, his hand fisted in my hair, my name on his lips. I swallowed and looked up at him. His eyes were glazed, his chest heaving.

"Come here," he said.

I crawled up his body and he pulled me against his chest. We lay tangled together, both of us satisfied, both of us spent. His hand stroked my back in lazy patterns.

"Next time," he said, "I'm going to be inside you."

The words sent heat through me all over again. "Yeah?"

"Yeah. But not today. Today was just a taste."

I looked at the clock on his nightstand. It was ten in the morning. Silas had classes until three. "I should go soon."

"Not yet. Stay a little longer."

So I stayed. We dozed, his body warm against mine. When I woke he was watching me, his hand tracing the curve of my waist.

"What are you thinking?" I asked.

"That I want to do this again. Soon."

"Tomorrow?"

"You can get away tomorrow?"

"I'll find a way."

He smiled and pulled me into a kiss. This one was slow and deep, full of promise. When we finally broke apart I got dressed while he watched from the bed.

"Same time?" he asked.

"Earlier. Seven. I'll tell him I'm going for a run."

"You don't run."

"I'm starting."

At the door he pulled me close for one more kiss. His hands cupped my face and I felt the tenderness in it, something beyond just physical want.

"Be careful going back down," he said.

"I will."